



**Charles
University**

ACTION PLAN

Charles University (CU), as the leading Czech university with international ambitions, places significant emphasis on enhancing the quality of its research and other creative activities. To this end, CU has developed a system of independent international research evaluation to be conducted every five years. The first evaluation cycle, covering the years 2014-2018, was completed in 2021. The subsequent cycle, focusing on the period of 2019-2023, has been shaped by CU's recent affiliation with the Coalition for Advancing Research Assessment (CoARA) in the autumn of 2022. Consequently, this second evaluation cycle is based on the principles of the Agreement on Reforming Research Assessment (ARRA).

Recognizing its leading role in the Czech research landscape, CU aims to serve as an example for other universities and research institutions in Czechia through its comprehensive approach to evaluating creative activities. The objective of the evaluation is to obtain precise and unbiased information about the quality of research at CU via international benchmarking and to guide the university's future development based on these insights. The evaluation serves as a critical tool for achieving an international standard of research excellence and strengthening CU's status as a prestigious European research institution.

The research evaluation outlined in this Action Plan is centrally organised by the rectorate of CU. Therefore, it concentrates on the assessment of entire research areas rather than detailing individual researchers and academics. Nonetheless, we are committed to encouraging the faculties to adopt the principal commitments of ARRA in their own assessment processes.

PROPOSED CONCEPT OF EVALUATION OF RESEARCH AT CHARLES UNIVERSITY:

The second cycle of the internal evaluation of research will cover the years 2019-2023. The assessment will focus on the academic quality of research areas as defined by the university's internal classification system. This system was developed in response to the outcome and feedback from the first evaluation cycle, during which the international board expressed confusion due to the extensive fragmentation of scientific disciplines across different faculties. To address this, 43 research areas have been identified within the university. Each area is managed by a board comprising members from all faculties involved in that specific research area. This structure is designed to foster inter-faculty communication and collaboration.

The objective of the evaluation is to provide critical feedback to those responsible for research at CU and its faculties by benchmarking their performance against international standards and offering specific recommendations to enhance international competitiveness.

During the preparations for the current evaluation cycle, the Agreement on Reforming Research Assessment (ARRA) was published (CU was part of the preparation process), and CU was among the first signatories in November 2022. As a result, we were able to incorporate ARRA's commitments into our evaluation concept. The three main adjustments we have made regarding the implementation of ARRA were reducing the role of bibliometric data, highlighting the university's third role and its societal impact, and incorporating onsite visits as one of the evaluation tools.





EVALUATION PROCESS

The current evaluation cycle has been prepared by the rectorate under the guidance of the Vice-Rector for Research. The evaluation concept underwent extensive discussions with the university's management, advisory bodies (both internal and external, including international bodies), and representatives from the faculties and research areas. These discussions lasted more than one year. The final version of the evaluation process was officially approved and initiated by the university's management in March 2024, with an anticipated completion by the end of 2025.

The success, effectiveness, and acceptance of the evaluation results among university members largely depend on the quality of the evaluators and their assessments. There are two evaluation bodies coordinating, organising and carrying out the assessment:

- **EVALUATION BOARD:**

- It coordinates and oversees the evaluation process.
- Its members are chairpersons of the four Evaluation Panels; therefore, they are involved in the assessment of specific research areas and ensure the calibration of the assessment across disciplines.
- It participates in onsite visits to different faculties and research workplaces to gain a deeper understanding of the research environment and to engage directly with the management and researchers (senior, junior, and PhD students).
- It prepares the final evaluation reports for each research area, summarising the findings from the assessment process (Self-evaluation reports, information gathered during the onsite visits) and providing critical feedback and recommendations for the future development of each research area.

- **EVALUATION PANELS:**

- Four expert panels (humanities, social sciences, natural sciences, medicine) offer detailed, discipline-specific assessments.
- The evaluators (and their expert and academic experience) are the benchmarks against which the assessment is carried out.
- They assess the Self-evaluation reports prepared by the individual research areas and prepare a written review, accompanied by a proposed grade, which is handed to the Board as input for their final evaluation reports.
- Each panel will discuss the grades for individual research areas to ensure the grading is consistent and fair within the panel.

The evaluation is based on the Self-evaluation reports prepared by representatives from each research area, supplemented significantly by onsite visits scheduled for the latter half of the evaluation cycle. The content of the **SELF-EVALUATION REPORT** is as follows:

- basic information about the research area – overview of the research area, its scope and focus,
- personnel situation – staff situation, key researchers (both senior and junior),
- research outputs – key scientific contributions of the research area,
- research funding, scientific cooperation – both national and international,





- impact of research - societal impact of research, third role of the university, communication and promotion of science.

The Self-evaluation report is supported by underlying data, including the number of researchers, PhD students, and details on age, gender, and nationality distribution within the research area. Additionally, it provides a basic distribution of publications by quartiles according to the Article Influence Score (AIS) and Source Normalized Impact per Paper (SNIP). The purpose of this "hard" data is to contextualise the specific research area—its size, capacity, and other characteristics. However, it is important to note that these data are not the focus of the evaluation; they serve merely to provide background and contextual information. The core of the evaluation stems from the nominations in excellent research outputs, individual researchers, teams, projects, applied research, and communication of research in each evaluated research area.

The second evaluation tool is the **ONSITE VISITS** by Board members and representatives of the research areas. These visits are organised after the evaluators have reviewed the Self-evaluation reports. The purpose of onsite visits is to gain a deeper insight into the specific research environment, culture, infrastructure, and resources of each research area. During these visits, evaluators can clarify any uncertainties and confirm the accuracy of their assessment. Onsite visits also facilitate open dialogue, allowing discussions of sensitive issues. The visits provide the opportunity to interact with a broader spectrum of researchers and administrative staff. The insights gained from onsite visits can help the evaluators provide more customised and relevant feedback to the representatives of each research area.

The outcome of the evaluation will be 43 detailed evaluation reports, one for each research area, each accompanied by a proposed grade. Additionally, the Board will compile a comprehensive overall report summarising the evaluation process. This report will provide feedback on the process and highlight key recommendations for the university management to enhance research excellence and boost international competitiveness. The assessment results will guide university management in refining research policies and strategies, funding mechanisms, etc. The assessment should identify the university's main strengths and weaknesses, offering recommendations to either exploit these strengths or address the weaknesses. We also expect that after the evaluation is finished, we will be able to highlight the most outstanding research areas or teams that CU should support prominently. Additionally, the evaluation will identify disciplines that are underperforming, providing insight into the reasons for this and suggesting approaches to address these issues. Lastly, the outcomes will influence the allocation of institutional resources among the research areas.





FULLFILLING THE COMMITMENTS:

Below, we outline our approach to fulfilling the commitments we agreed to by signing the Agreement.

C1: Recognise the diversity of contributions to, and careers in, research in accordance with the needs and nature of the research

- Broadening assessment criteria - the evaluated units are encouraged to include in the Self-assessment report:
 - other forms of outputs than articles and books - the system is not limited to a strict list of recognisable types of results and outputs,
 - other types of contributions such as public engagement, mentoring, interdisciplinary collaboration etc.
- Career path recognition:
 - A specific part of the Self-evaluation report is dedicated to the early-career researchers
- Adapt the evaluation to fit the nature of different research areas:
 - The Self-evaluation report serves as a commentary on the current state of research in the area, allowing authors the flexibility to adjust the information to meet their specific needs.
 - In sections of the Self-evaluation report that require examples, the authors have the flexibility to choose the types of examples they provide (the system allows nominations from both basic and applied research, creative outputs within societal engagement, the third role of the university etc.).
 - The purpose of the process is to show the diversity of contributions that differ in each research field.

C2: Base research assessment primarily on qualitative evaluation for which peer review is central, supported by responsible use of quantitative indicators

- Reduction of the quantitative indicators – only basic quantitative data such as number of researchers, PhD students, age distribution, gender distribution, and basic bibliometric information (distribution of the outputs by AIS and SNIP) are used to show the context (and size) of the specific research area; these data are not subject to evaluation.
- Enhancing the peer review process - our focus is on qualitative evaluation; the outcome of this evaluation is a report that critically comments on the content of the Self-evaluation report.

C3: Abandon inappropriate uses in research assessment of journal- and publication-based metrics, in particular inappropriate uses of Journal Impact Factor (JIF) and h-index

- As stated above, the journal- and publication-based metrics are used only as an underlying information about the size of the field/area, these data are not supposed to be assessed individually.
- The evaluated units may include indicators, citations, and other relevant metrics in the appropriate sections of the Self-evaluation report; we acknowledge and respect the specific relevance of these indicators to their respective research fields.

C4: Avoid the use of rankings of research organisations in research assessment





- The university rankings do not affect the CU internal evaluation in any way.

C5: Commit resources to reforming research assessment as is needed to achieve the organisational changes committed to

- CU has already completed one cycle of internal evaluation; therefore, we are well aware of the costs associated with this demanding process.
- From the beginning, we were communicating this issue with the university bodies and a realistic budget has been allocated for financing the evaluation process.

C6: Review and develop research assessment criteria, tools and processes

- Feedback from the first evaluation cycle, which finished in 2021, has been collected from the evaluators, the evaluated units and the organisational team as well.
- After CU became a signatory of the ARRA, we have made several changes in the evaluation concept to align with the qualitative principles of assessment.
- A working group had been formed to involve the community in the preparatory phase of the evaluation; it included representatives from the CU management (Vice-Rector for Research), faculty representatives and researchers and administrative staff (research support office of the rectorate) as well. The working group served as a platform to discuss the evaluation concept and to collect initial feedback.

C7: Raise awareness of research assessment reform and provide transparent communication, guidance, and training on assessment criteria and processes as well as their use

- We devoted a year to developing and sharing the evaluation concept with faculties, we presented it multiple times at the CU leadership meetings and other forums. However, there is some resistance and aversion to certain commitments within the evaluation process. For instance, scholars in the natural sciences and medical disciplines have expressed doubts about abandoning quantitative indicators and metrics. Additionally, the budget allocated for the evaluation is a sensitive topic in the context of the underfunded higher education sector.
- The evaluation will be conducted strictly by international evaluators who have no conflicts of interest with CU. The evaluators will be properly guided and trained on the evaluation process, assessment criteria, and their use.
- We will collect feedback from all relevant participants of the evaluation during and after the process, with the goal of improving the next research evaluation cycle.
- After receiving the outcomes of the evaluation, we will make the parts that can be disclosed available to the academic community.

C8: Exchange practices and experiences to enable mutual learning within and beyond the Coalition

- We publish this Action Plan to share our approach to incorporating the commitments proposed by ARRA and endorsed by CoARA into our university's evaluation process.
- We have introduced our evaluation system to several Czech universities and will continue to do so once we establish a Czech National Chapter.
- We will continue to monitor developments within CoARA, including the topics discussed and other relevant activities.
- We present our approach towards evaluation to the national level players (mainly the Ministry of Education, which is also a signatory of ARRA) as a showcase of a complex





evaluation process building on the principles of ARRA and CoARA within a large, heterogeneous research institution.

C9: Communicate progress made on adherence to the principles and implementation of the Commitments

- This Action plan is the foundational document outlining our approach to implementing research evaluation at CU. After the completion of the second evaluation cycle (at the end of 2025), we will publish a follow-up report that provides critical feedback on the evaluation system, along with suggestions for its refinement and improvement.
- Feedback from the evaluation, as well as a report on how CU is implementing the Commitments, will be presented and discussed within CoARA, and among CU management, faculties and academic staff who have an interest in this topic.

C10: Evaluate practices, criteria and tools based on solid evidence and the state-of-the-art in research on research, and make data openly available for evidence gathering and research

- A summary of the evaluation, including general outcomes, will be made publicly available on the university's website. This will provide transparent access to the key findings and insights from the evaluation process.
- Also, the underlying data and the completed Self-evaluation reports will be accessible to the academic community at CU. This is aimed at fostering an environment of transparency by allowing the community to understand the data upon which the evaluation was based.

CONCLUDING REMARKS:

The evaluation concept outlined above is a centrally organised process initiated by the CU management, focusing on the research at CU as a whole. The follow-up aim is to integrate the commitments of the ARRA into the various types of evaluation conducted at the faculties and other CU units. This includes evaluation of departments and institutes, as well as assessment of individual researchers and students. Implementing the approaches of ARRA in the heterogeneous and autonomous environment of a public university is a significant challenge.

We will focus on and motivate the management of the faculties to disseminate the fundamentals of the ARRA concept. We demonstrate how we have incorporated the commitments into the central evaluation, and we will provide guidance to the faculties on how to adapt these principles, considering the specifics of each faculty and unit.

Extending the ARRA principles to the lower levels of the university's hierarchy, including career planning processes, is a critical task. We will devise strategies to highlight and promote the positive aspects of responsible assessment. Our goal is to foster a culture of responsible research assessment across the entire university.

